

D483

Security Operations

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

Method © 2026 Erik Daniel Lindquist — Course Mastery Coach, armored drill. Items drafted with AI assistance under his direction.

How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A SOC analyst at a 2,000-employee insurer has isolated three infected laptops from the network. The alert came in on a holiday weekend. Following the NIST incident response lifecycle, what comes next?

- A. Write the lessons-learned report.
- B. Reconnect the laptops so users can work.
- C. Eradicate the malware and its cause, then recover the laptops.
- D. Return to the preparation phase.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which activity belongs to the preparation phase of incident response?

- A. Triaging a new alert.
- B. Writing playbooks, training responders, and setting up tools and contacts.
- C. Writing the lessons-learned report.
- D. Isolating an infected host.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

An IDS logs that an employee's workstation connected to a domain listed as a known command-and-control server in a trusted threat feed. The employee works in accounting and joined last month. How should this be classified?

- A. Just an event; there is no incident until data is stolen.
- B. Nothing; IDS alerts are always false positives.
- C. An incident because the employee is new.
- D. An incident; start the response process.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A web server is confirmed compromised and attacker activity is ongoing. The server hosts the company's holiday promotion site, built by an intern. What is the best immediate action?

- A. Pull the power plug.
- B. Wipe and reinstall it right away.
- C. Isolate the server from the network and capture evidence such as memory before any rebuild.
- D. Leave it running untouched to watch the attacker longer.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

Evidence sources on a running compromised server include RAM, the local disk, logs already forwarded to a remote syslog server, and archived backup tapes. The server sits in a colocation facility 40 miles away. What should be collected first?

- A. The local disk
- B. Remote syslog
- C. RAM
- D. Archived backup tapes

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Why is a documented chain of custody kept for a seized hard drive?

- A. To show who handled it and when, so it can be trusted and used in legal action.
- B. Only when police are already involved.
- C. To speed up the analysis.
- D. To encrypt the drive.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A threat feed shares file hashes and IP addresses tied to a ransomware group. The feed is paid for annually and covers 30 industries. What kind of intelligence is this, and how is it best used?

- A. Indicators of attack describing behavior.
- B. Tactical/technical IOCs; load them into detection tools and use them to hunt.
- C. Use it only in the annual budget report.
- D. Strategic intelligence for the board.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A SIEM rule fires 900 alerts a day, and analysts find about 3 are real. The SIEM came from a leading vendor. What is the problem, and what is the fix?

- A. Disable the rule.
- B. Too many false positives; tune thresholds, add context, and exclude known-good activity.
- C. Hire analysts to review all 900.
- D. Switch SIEM vendors.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

After aggressive tuning, a real intrusion produced no alert. What is this called?

- A. A false negative.
- B. A false positive.
- C. A true positive.
- D. A true negative.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A company buys cyber insurance to cover breach costs. The policy was chosen after three meetings with brokers. Which risk treatment is this?

- A. Transfer
- B. Accept
- C. Mitigate
- D. Avoid

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Management shuts down a legacy file-upload service because its risk outweighs its value. Which treatment is this?

- A.** Accept
- B.** Transfer
- C.** Mitigate
- D.** Avoid

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A retailer's breach exposed personal data of EU residents. The breach was discovered on a Friday by a contractor. Under GDPR, when must the supervisory authority generally be notified?

- A.** Only after the investigation is fully finished.
- B.** Within 72 hours of when the breach began.
- C.** Within 30 days.
- D.** Without undue delay and, where feasible, within 72 hours of becoming aware.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer C Concept 1

A SOC analyst at a 2,000-employee insurer has isolated three infected laptops from the network. ~~The alert came in on a holiday weekend.~~ Following the NIST incident response lifecycle, what comes next?

Target word: next step after containment **Decides:** Containment is done; the threat is still on the machines.

A	Dropped element	Skips eradication and recovery.
B	Adjacent category	Recovery before eradication brings the threat back.
C	Correct	Eradication and recovery follow containment.
D	Inverted operation	Preparation comes before incidents, not in the middle.

2. Answer B Concept 1 • transfer

Which activity belongs to the preparation phase of incident response?

Target word: reverse: phase to activity **Decides:** Preparation happens before incidents.

A	Confusion set	That is detection and analysis.
B	Correct	Builds the ability to respond before it is needed.
C	Inverted operation	That is post-incident activity.
D	Adjacent category	That is containment.

3. Answer D Concept 2

An IDS logs that an employee's workstation connected to a domain listed as a known command-and-control server in a trusted threat feed. ~~The employee works in accounting and joined last month.~~ How should this be classified?

Target word: event or incident **Decides:** Evidence points to a likely compromise.

A	Dropped element	Incidents include imminent threats, not only confirmed losses.
B	Absolute language	Many alerts are real, and this one matches trusted intel.
C	Camouflage	Tenure is not why it qualifies.
D	Correct	Contact with a known control server is an imminent threat to policy.

4. Answer C Concept 3

A web server is confirmed compromised and attacker activity is ongoing. ~~The server hosts the company's holiday promotion site, built by an intern.~~ What is the best immediate action?

Target word: immediate response **Decides:** Ongoing activity and a need to keep evidence.

A	Confusion set	Loses volatile evidence in memory.
B	Dropped element	Destroys evidence and skips finding the cause.
C	Correct	Stops the spread while keeping what investigators need.
D	Adjacent category	Lets damage continue without containment.

5. Answer C Concept 4

Evidence sources on a running compromised server include RAM, the local disk, logs already forwarded to a remote syslog server, and archived backup tapes. ~~The server sits in a colocation facility 40 miles away.~~ What should be collected first?

Target word: collection order **Decides:** RAM is the most volatile.

A	Adjacent category	Less volatile than memory.
B	Confusion set	Already preserved off the host.
C	Correct	Memory is lost on shutdown, so it goes first.
D	Inverted operation	The least volatile source.

6. Answer A Concept 4 • transfer

Why is a documented chain of custody kept for a seized hard drive?

Target word: purpose of the control **Decides:** Proving evidence was not altered.

A	Correct	Gaps in custody weaken the evidence.
B	Absolute language	Legal action may come later; keep custody from the start.
C	Adjacent category	It adds steps; its value is trust.
D	Confusion set	Custody is documentation, not encryption.

7. Answer B Concept 5

A threat feed shares file hashes and IP addresses tied to a ransomware group. ~~The feed is paid for annually and covers 30 industries.~~ What kind of intelligence is this, and how is it best used?

Target word: intel level and use **Decides:** Hashes and IPs are technical indicators.

A	Adjacent category	IOAs describe actions; hashes and IPs are IOCs.
B	Correct	Indicators are made for machines and hunters.
C	Camouflage	Follows the annual-fee detail and wastes the data.
D	Confusion set	Strategic intel covers trends and business risk, not hashes.

8. Answer B Concept 6

A SIEM rule fires 900 alerts a day, and analysts find about 3 are real. ~~The SIEM came from a leading vendor.~~ What is the problem, and what is the fix?

Target word: diagnose and tune **Decides:** Mostly false positives.

A	Dropped element	Creates false negatives for the real 3.
B	Correct	Tuning keeps detection while cutting noise.
C	Adjacent category	Treats the symptom and adds cost.
D	Camouflage	The rule logic, not the vendor, is the issue.

9. Answer A Concept 6 · transfer

After aggressive tuning, a real intrusion produced no alert. What is this called?

Target word: name the error **Decides:** A real attack went undetected.

A	Correct	The event was malicious but not flagged.
B	Inverted operation	That is an alert on something harmless.
C	Adjacent category	That would be a correct alert.
D	Confusion set	That is correctly not alerting on harmless activity.

10. Answer A Concept 7

A company buys cyber insurance to cover breach costs. ~~The policy was chosen after three meetings with brokers.~~ Which risk treatment is this?

Target word: treatment **Decides:** Financial impact shifts to an insurer.

A	Correct	Insurance moves the financial impact to another party.
B	Adjacent category	Acceptance takes no action beyond documenting.
C	Confusion set	Mitigation lowers likelihood or impact with controls.
D	Inverted operation	Avoidance stops the risky activity.

11. Answer D Concept 7 · transfer

Management shuts down a legacy file-upload service because its risk outweighs its value. Which treatment is this?

Target word: reverse: action to treatment **Decides:** The activity itself is stopped.

A	Inverted operation	Acceptance keeps the service running.
B	Confusion set	Nothing is shifted to another party.
C	Adjacent category	Mitigation keeps the service and adds controls.
D	Correct	Ending the activity removes the risk.

12. Answer D Concept 8

A retailer's breach exposed personal data of EU residents. ~~The breach was discovered on a Friday by a contractor.~~ Under GDPR, when must the supervisory authority generally be notified?

Target word: notification timing **Decides:** GDPR's clock starts at awareness.

A	Dropped element	Notification can be made in phases as facts emerge.
B	Confusion set	The clock runs from awareness, not from the start of the breach.
C	Adjacent category	Some other laws use longer windows; GDPR does not.
D	Correct	The GDPR standard for notifying the authority.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	5	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	11	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	6	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	2	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	9	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	3	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Incident response lifecycle	NIST: preparation; detection and analysis; containment, eradication, and recovery; post-incident activity — in that order.	Restoring systems before the threat is removed, or skipping to lessons learned.	“What comes next?” after a named phase.
2	Event vs. incident	An event is any observable occurrence; an incident is a violation or imminent threat of violation of security policy.	Waiting for confirmed data theft before calling it an incident.	An alert showing a likely compromise.
3	Containment and evidence	Contain first (isolate), preserve evidence, then eradicate and recover.	Wiping or powering off right away.	“Confirmed compromise, activity ongoing.”
4	Order of volatility and chain of custody	Collect the most volatile evidence first (memory before disk before archives) and document every hand-off.	Imaging the disk first, or treating custody logs as optional.	A list of evidence sources on a running system.
5	Threat intelligence levels	Strategic intel informs leaders; operational describes campaigns; tactical and technical intel (IOCs such as hashes and IPs) feeds tools directly.	Using IOC feeds only for reports.	Hashes and IP addresses in a feed.
6	Detection tuning	False positives cause alert fatigue; false negatives are missed attacks. Tune rules with context rather than disabling them.	Turning a noisy rule off, which creates false negatives.	Hundreds of alerts with few real ones.
7	Risk treatment	Mitigate (reduce), transfer (insurance, contracts), avoid (stop the activity), or accept (documented decision).	Calling insurance mitigation.	Insurance, stopping a service, or adding a control.
8	Breach notification duties	Follow law and policy with legal counsel; under GDPR, notify the supervisory authority without undue delay and, where feasible, within 72 hours of becoming aware.	Waiting until the investigation is complete, or counting from when the breach began.	Personal data exposure and a clock.

Course scope (public description): Security Operations provides learners with the fundamental skills to handle and respond to computer security incidents in an information system. The course addresses various underlying principles and techniques for detecting and responding to current and emerging computer security threats. The course also helps learners explore strategies to leverage intelligence and threat detection techniques, analyze and interpret data, identify, and address vulnerabilities, and suggest preventative measures. Methods are introduced to effectively respond to and recover from cybersecurity incidents, evaluate risk assessment methodologies, and apply incident handling laws and policies.